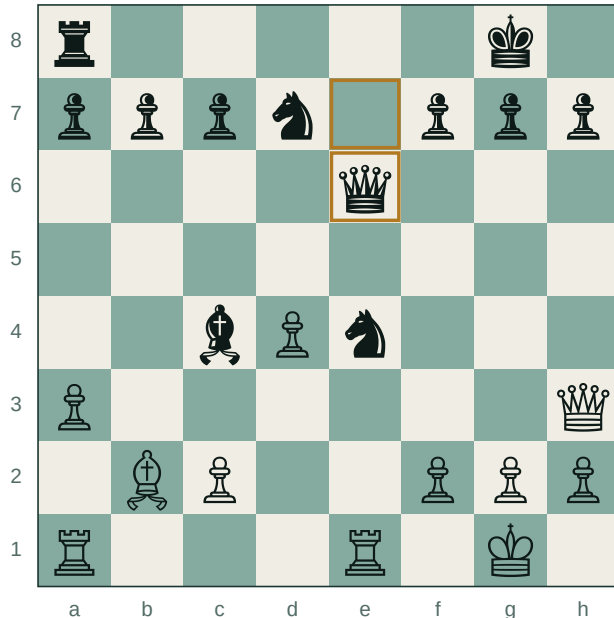


Capture the defender: White, move 18

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 17...Qe6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Qxe6 Bxe6 19. Rxe4

18.Qxe6 The queen captures the queen on e6. From e6 it attacks knight on e4, knight on d7 and bishop on c4.
Recorded reply: **18...Bxe6**.

19.Rxe4 The rook captures the knight on e4.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.